



WRONG RITES

CHILD BRIDE Urmila (12) with her husband Kishan Gopal (15) in a mass marriage outside his village near Kota, Rajasthan. Despite a ban on child marriages, many below the legal age are still married on 'Akshaya Tritiya', an auspicious day for Hindus.

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As part of his planned series of internal reforms, army chief General V.K. Singh has initiated a comprehensive review of the force's promotion policy. Officers with field postings in counter-insurgency areas will now be given more points than those in peacetime stations. This corrects a major anomaly in a controversial policy introduced by his predecessor general Deepak Kapoor. The shortcoming was apparently exemplified by recruitment posters that showcased the good life in the army—officers partying and playing golf. The old policy treated officers in cushy peace postings on the same scale as those in counter-insurgency operations. Even as the review, which was recently discussed at the army commanders' conference, is a while away from implementation, it is part of a new thinking within the army. "The new initiative comes from a combat veteran and is a cleansing process that rewards the fighting spirit of the army," says major-general (ret'd) G.D. Bakshi.

by Sandeep Unnithan



SINGH (CENTRE)

POSTINGS IN COMBAT ZONES WILL BE GIVEN MORE IMPORTANCE WHILE ASSESSING OFFICERS.